#EconTwitter and Elon Musk: Anatomy of a Failed Exodus*

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Abstract

We study the attempted migration of the #EconTwitter community from Twitter/X to Mastodon following Elon Musk's acquisition of the platform. Leveraging a dataset of 4.3 million tweets from over 2,000 economists—including detailed records of their weekly activity and network-mediated exposure to peers' Mastodon-related retweets—we examine how peer discussions relate to platform engagement. In a difference-in-differences framework, we estimate that greater exposure to Mastodon-related discussions is followed by a short-run decline in activity on Twitter/X. However, this relationship attenuates substantially when we control for economist fixed effects or examine longer-run behavior. Two years later, economists with higher Mastodon exposure are somewhat more likely to multi-home across platforms but only marginally less active on Twitter/X. These findings highlight the strength of network effects and the difficulty of disrupting incumbent platforms, even during periods of widespread discontent.

JEL Classification:
Keywords: Network effects, social media, Twitter/X, EconTwitter.

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1 Introduction

Social media platforms derive much of their value from network effects, with Twitter (now X) offering a quintessential example, boasting 237.8 million monetizable daily active users as of Q2 2022 [Twitter, Inc., 2022]. The platform's dominance stems from its large user base of content providers and intricate social connections—personal friends and influencers—creating strong incentives for user retention [Ellison et al., 2007]. These network effects generate economies of scale, reinforcing Twitter/X's market dominance and acting as a barrier to competitors [Economides, 1996a]. For users, this creates lock-in: when colleagues and influential figures remain, switching platforms is less appealing [Zhu and Iansiti, 2012]. Isolated exit attempts rarely disrupt Twitter/X's position, but a major platform shock can, in principle, weaken this lock-in [Arthur, 1989].

This paper examines such a shock by analyzing the attempted and ultimately failed #EconTwitter exodus from Twitter/X. We assemble a dataset of 4.3 million tweets from over 2,000 economists and use user-level weekly data to characterize behavioral responses around Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter in October 2022 [Reuters, 2022]. The takeover was followed by controversial changes, including large-scale layoffs and other policy shifts that generated widespread dissatisfaction [Bloomberg, 2023]. These developments were especially salient within the #EconTwitter community, an influential network of economists, students, journalists, and policymakers. Using the network structure of our data, we construct measures of each user's exposure to Mastodon-related discussions through retweets by accounts they follow, and we relate this exposure to subsequent changes in Twitter/X activity.

Our study has two objectives. First, we provide a comprehensive analysis of user activity during the attempted exodus and ask whether responses were concentrated among more influential users—those with larger follower bases—in ways consistent with peer effects and network propagation. Second, we explore the role of Mastodon, a competing social media platform, as a potential outside option during this period. Many users publicly announced their intention to migrate, and Mastodon-related content circulated widely in the #EconTwitter network. By comparing users who were differentially exposed to such discussions through their networks, we assess whether and how migration talk translated into changes in engagement on Twitter/X.

Despite initial enthusiasm for migration, our findings suggest that the exodus was ultimately unsuccessful. Difference-in-differences estimates indicate a brief decline in activity following heightened exposure to Mastodon-related discussions, but engagement levels quickly rebounded, underscoring the resilience of Twitter/X's network effects. Longer-run evidence also points to only modest impacts on Twitter/X usage. The platform's entrenched position, bolstered by a vast and interconnected user base, proved too strong for decentralized and uncoordinated user actions to substantially diminish its dominance. In the end, users in the #EconTwitter community appear to have found Twitter/X's utility as a communication and networking tool too valuable to abandon, even in the face of dissatisfaction with platform changes.

Our analysis contributes to the broader literature on network effects and their implications for market dominance and antitrust concerns. The persistence of Twitter/X's market power echoes longstanding debates within this field. Katz and Shapiro [1985] demonstrate how network effects can entrench monopolistic behavior through strategic compatibility, while Economides [1996b] highlights how such effects create significant entry barriers, leading to market concentration. Farrell and Klemperer [2007] argue that network effects, combined with switching costs, pose substantial challenges for competition and raise antitrust concerns. Rysman [2009] extends this analysis to two-sided markets, where network effects enhance the market power of platforms like Twitter/X. Armstrong [2006] similarly emphasizes the role of network effects in shaping pricing strategies and market structures in two-sided markets, ultimately reinforcing monopolistic tendencies. Recent works by Khan [2017] and Hovenkamp [2021] further highlight the antitrust challenges posed by digital platform dominance. Conversely, Liebowitz and Margolis [1990] and Liebowitz and Margolis [1995] offer a counterpoint, suggesting that path dependence and lock-in are not inevitable and that market forces may overcome initial disadvantages if superior technologies emerge. These conflicting perspectives highlight the importance of empirical evidence in understanding the persistence of network effects and their impact on market dynamics.

While much of the existing literature focuses on the supply side, particularly the strategies of firms, our study shifts the focus to the demand side by examining how users interact with platforms shaped by network effects. Our empirical findings illustrate how network effects can reinforce market power, even in the face of user dissatisfaction, thus contributing to ongoing antitrust debates [Scott Morton et al., 2023]. To the best of our knowledge, this study is among the first to provide systematic empirical evidence on a high-profile failed attempt to disrupt an entrenched social media platform with strong network effects. By focusing on the #EconTwitter migration episode, we offer new insights into how network effects shape platform stability in real-world market conditions.

Additionally, our study contributes to the burgeoning literature on social media's role as an academic community. Recent research has examined the dynamics of #EconTwitter, with Ajzenman et al. [2023] finding that users are more likely to follow accounts of white students, those from prestigious institutions, and female students. Our work builds on these insights by documenting the resilience of this academic network during a period of platform disruption. The desire to remain connected to peers and participate in intellectual exchanges provides a strong incentive for continued engagement, even amid substantial dissatisfaction, underscoring the importance of network effects within specialized communities.

2 Data and Summary Statistics

2.1 Twitter/X API

We use the Twitter/X API to collect tweet-level data and account metadata through March 2023, when X discontinued free API access. The API provides rich information on each tweet and its author, including the author ID, timestamp, text content, language, and public engagement metrics (retweets, likes, replies, and quotes). For each author ID, we also observe account-level metadata such as the total number of tweets ever posted by the user and follower counts as of the end of our sample period. On the network side, we collect a snapshot of the accounts each author ID follows, which we use to proxy for the set of accounts whose content is plausibly available in the user's feed and to construct network-mediated exposure measures.

Our dataset has two overlapping components. The first consists of tweets containing the hashtag #EconTwitter, which we use to describe community-level dynamics and the evolution of migration-related discussions. The second consists of tweets from a sample of 2,321 economists identified using the RePEc (Research Papers in Economics) database. The latter sample is the basis for our user-level panel analyses.

2.1.1 #EconTwitter

We collected 680,494 tweets that contain the hashtag #EconTwitter, a commonly used tag among economists, academics, and researchers on Twitter/X to share insights, papers, and discussions related to economics. Figure 1 summarizes weekly trends in original #EconTwitter tweets and the share of #EconTwitter tweets that mention Mastodon-related keywords.

[Figure 1 about here.]

Two salient platform events in late 2022, following Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter, coincided with noticeable changes in #EconTwitter activity. First, Twitter implemented large-scale layoffs on November 4, 2022, which generated uncertainty and dissatisfaction among users. Second, Twitter began rolling out a paid subscription model for verification (Twitter Blue), priced at roughly $8 per month, with subsequent adjustments and relaunches later in 2022. These events sparked widespread reactions, including public outcry and discussions of leaving the platform.

Following the layoffs, the number of original #EconTwitter tweets dropped sharply, and the decline continued through the subsequent weeks. Despite this drop, activity rebounded by early 2023, returning to levels comparable to those observed before these incidents. This pattern suggests that while engagement initially declined in response to platform upheaval, the #EconTwitter community displayed substantial resilience.

During this period, some users in the #EconTwitter community explored Mastodon as a potential alternative. Mastodon, an open-source social media platform launched in 2016, positions itself as a decentralized and non-commercial substitute to platforms like Twitter/X. In the weeks following Musk's acquisition, tweets increasingly referenced Mastodon (often by sharing handles, encouraging others to join, or seeking recommendations for whom to follow). Figure 1 shows that Mastodon mentions rose sharply immediately after the layoffs, then declined, with another spike later in 2022. By the end of our sample in early 2023, Mastodon mentions fell back to below 1% of #EconTwitter tweets.

These descriptive patterns motivate our user-level analysis of whether exposure to Mastodon-related discussions through one's social network is associated with subsequent changes in Twitter/X activity.

2.1.2 RePEc Database

A second key data source is the RePEc (Research Papers in Economics) database, which we use to identify economists who are active on Twitter/X. We cross-reference RePEc listings of living economists with Twitter/X accounts to compile a sample of 2,321 economists. Using the Twitter/X API, we retrieve up to 3,000 of the most recent tweets for each economist as of March 2023, yielding a total of 4.3 million tweets. Each tweet is linked to metadata including author ID, timestamp, text content, language, and engagement metrics. For each of the 2,321 economists, we also collect a snapshot of the accounts they follow, enabling us to study network connections alongside content creation.

Economists in our sample exhibit substantial exposure to #EconTwitter activity. Each economist follows an average of 1,300 accounts, and 99% follow at least one account that posted #EconTwitter content during our sample period. There is also notable exposure to Mastodon-related discussions: 84% of economists follow at least one account that posted a

#EconTwitter tweet mentioning "Mastodon" (as defined below). These network data allow us to construct measures of exposure to migration-related discussions within economists' online peer networks.

2.2 Mastodon Exposure

To quantify an economist's exposure to Mastodon-related discussions—a proxy for exposure to peers' interest in alternative platforms—we identify tweets that mention "Mastodon" and closely related keywords.[1] Our exposure measures are constructed using the follow network and retweet structure observed in the Twitter/X API data.

A simple (direct) exposure proxy is the number of Mastodon-related tweets posted by accounts that economist i follows in week t. Because we do not observe impressions, this measure is interpreted as content that is plausibly available to i through the accounts in i's follow set.

A central challenge in estimating social influence is that network connections may reflect shared preferences (homophily) and simultaneity in behavior, raising concerns related to the reflection problem [Manski, 1993]. Motivated by the "peers of peers" logic in Bramoullé et al. [2009] (see also Lee [2007] and Lin [2010]), we construct an indirect exposure measure that exploits intransitivity in the follow graph. Specifically, we focus on Mastodon-related content that reaches user i through retweets by accounts that i follows, where the original author is not followed by i. This design reduces direct selection into the set of original (non-followed) accounts while capturing how peers can transmit migration-related content.

Figure 2 illustrates the structure: User A follows User B but not User C. When User B retweets a Mastodon-related post originally written by User C, User A becomes indirectly exposed to User C's content despite the absence of a direct tie.

[Figure 2 about here.]

[1] Twitter/X at one point restricted links and content related to Mastodon; users also adopted alternative terms such as "other site," "elephant site," "m*stodon," "trunk," and "econtoot." We include these alternative terms when identifying Mastodon-related tweets.

Formally, for each economist i in week t, we define $RetweetMastodon_{it}$ as the number of Mastodon-related retweets performed by accounts followed by i where the original author of the retweeted post is not followed by i. We then construct cumulative exposure up to week t as

$$MastodonExposure_{it} = \sum_{s<t} RetweetMastodon_{is}.$$

This cumulative retweet-based exposure measure is our main proxy for network-mediated exposure to Mastodon-related discussions in the user-level analyses that follow.

2.3 Summary Statistics of the RePEc Sample

Table 1 presents summary statistics for the RePEc sample, comparing users with high and low exposure to Mastodon-related content. The sample includes 2,321 living economists with active Twitter/X accounts. We use the median value of $MastodonExposure_{it}$ to split the sample into "High Exposure" and "Low Exposure" groups.

[Table 1 about here.]

Users with high exposure tend to follow more accounts on Twitter/X (1,923 on average) compared to those with low exposure (825 on average). They are also more active on the platform, posting an average of 15.17 tweets per week versus 9.86 for the low exposure group. These differences highlight the importance of accounting for persistent user heterogeneity in subsequent analyses. Interestingly, the average number of followers is higher for the low exposure group, suggesting that more established economists with larger followings may be less likely to be exposed to (or engage with) migration-related discussions during the sample period.

Table 2 summarizes changes in tweeting behavior before and after Musk's acquisition of Twitter/X for both exposure groups. We report weekly counts of tweets, retweets, replies, quote tweets, and #EconTwitter mentions.

[Table 2 about here.]

On average, both high and low exposure groups increased their overall tweeting activity in the post-acquisition period as defined in Table 2. However, the increase was more pronounced for the low exposure group, which saw a 22% rise in weekly tweet counts, compared to a 17% rise for the high exposure group. The high exposure group showed a larger increase in retweets and replies, consistent with relatively greater engagement during the period when Mastodon-related discussions were more salient.

2.4 Long Run Social Media Data

Because free Twitter/X API access ended in March 2023, we are unable to extend the tweet-level panel beyond that point using automated data collection. To assess longer-run platform usage, we constructed a snapshot of economists' social media presence as of May 2025.

We first scraped each economist's Twitter/X profile to determine whether the account still exists and, if so, to record the total tweet count as of May 2025. By comparing this number to the total tweet count recorded in March 2023, we proxy for each user's posting activity over the intervening period.[2]

To supplement this, we manually searched for each economist on two alternative platforms—Bluesky and Mastodon—both of which have gained traction among academics. For those with accounts on either platform, we scraped publicly available profile information, including the total number of posts and the date of the most recent post.

This composite dataset allows us to describe longer-run patterns of platform persistence, abandonment, and multi-homing well after the initial disruption.

Table 3 presents summary statistics on long-run social media outcomes by RePEc economists, disaggregated by their exposure to Mastodon-related content during our Twitter/X sample period. We report both extensive margin measures—whether an economist is active on each platform (Twitter/X, Bluesky, Mastodon)—and intensive margin measures—the number of posts

[2] Total tweet counts can also change due to deletions or account-level restrictions; we interpret differences as a summary proxy for net posting rather than a complete activity log.

made between March 2023 and May 2025.

On the extensive margin, economists in the High Exposure group are somewhat less likely to remain active on Twitter/X (87.5%) compared to the Low Exposure group (90.7%). In contrast, they are more likely to be active on Bluesky (66.3% vs. 46.0%) and Mastodon (15.6% vs. 6.1%). These differences suggest that higher exposure is associated with diversification across platforms, rather than complete departure from Twitter/X.

A similar pattern holds on the intensive margin. High Exposure economists posted fewer tweets on Twitter/X on average (766 vs. 917) and were slightly more active on Bluesky (272 vs. 266 posts). Interestingly, they were less active on Mastodon in terms of posting (239 vs. 579), despite being more likely to maintain an account there. This suggests that while exposure to Mastodon-related discussions correlates with account adoption on alternative platforms, it does not necessarily translate into sustained content production on Mastodon.

[Table 3 about here.]

3 Results and Interpretation

3.1 Difference-in-Differences Estimation

To evaluate how exposure to Mastodon-related discussions is related to tweeting behavior around the major X layoff in early November 2022, we estimate a difference-in-differences (DiD) specification with treatment intensity measured by cumulative exposure. The baseline model is

$$Y_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Layoff}_t + \beta_2 \text{MastodonExposure}_{it} + \beta_3 \big(\text{Layoff}_t \times \text{MastodonExposure}_{it}\big) + \beta_4 X_i + \epsilon_{it}, \tag{1}$$

where Y_{it} denotes weekly outcomes for economist i in week t. We consider both extensive-margin outcomes (e.g., an indicator for whether i tweets at all in week t, or whether i tweets on #EconTwitter in week t) and intensive-margin outcomes (weekly counts of tweets, retweets, replies, and quotes), estimated separately. The variable Layoff_t equals one for weeks after the mass layoff at X in early November 2022. $\text{MastodonExposure}_{it}$ is economist i's cumulative retweet-based exposure to Mastodon-related content (constructed using information prior to week t, as defined in Section 2.2). The interaction term $\text{Layoff}_t \times \text{MastodonExposure}_{it}$ captures whether the post-layoff change in activity differs systematically with exposure. Finally, X_i includes additional controls such as the number of followers, followings, and whether the account is verified.

Table 4 reports the estimated relationship between Mastodon exposure and changes in tweeting behavior following the layoff, on both the extensive and intensive margins.

[Table 4 about here.]

On the extensive margin, the estimates indicate a decline in participation following the layoff among economists with greater exposure to Mastodon-related discussions. For example, a one standard-deviation increase in cumulative Mastodon exposure (about 5.413 units in our sample) in the post-layoff period is associated with roughly a 6 percentage point lower likelihood of tweeting at all in a given week (0.0121×5.413). This pattern is consistent with the idea that migration-related discussions circulated through peer networks during the period of platform disruption and coincided with short-run reductions in activity.

On the intensive margin, we find corresponding declines in the volume of weekly activity. A one standard-deviation increase in cumulative Mastodon exposure after the layoff is associated with decreases of approximately 3 tweets, 0.8 retweets, 1.7 replies, and 0.4 quotes in a given week. Together, these results suggest that weeks with greater network-mediated exposure to Mastodon-related discussions are associated with lower engagement on X in the immediate post-layoff period.

At the same time, the DiD specification in equation (1) relies partly on cross-economist differences in exposure. In the next subsection, we therefore examine a within-economist specification that controls for time-invariant individual heterogeneity and common week-level shocks.

3.2 Economist Fixed-Effects Regression

Section 3.1 compares changes in behavior across economists with different levels of Mastodon exposure. In this subsection, we focus on short-run within-economist responses in a narrow event window: five weeks before and five weeks after the major X layoff in November 2022. This restricted period allows us to examine short-term changes while limiting confounding from longer-run platform dynamics.

We estimate the following fixed effects specification:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 RetweetMastodon_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \phi_t + \epsilon_{it}, \tag{2}$$

where Y_{it} denotes the same outcomes used in equation (1). δ_i are economist fixed effects and ϕ_t are week fixed effects. The regressor $RetweetMastodon_{i,t-1}$ is the retweet-based indirect Mastodon exposure in the prior week (as defined in Section 2.2): the number of Mastodon-related retweets transmitted to economist i by accounts i follows, where the original author of the retweeted post is not followed by i. Using the lagged exposure measure ensures that exposure precedes the week-t outcome.

Table 5 presents the estimates.

[Table 5 about here.]

Two findings stand out. First, on the extensive margin, increased exposure to Mastodon-related retweets is associated with only a small change in participation. A one standard-deviation increase in exposure is associated with about a 1.5 percentage point decrease in the probability of tweeting on #EconTwitter in the subsequent week. This suggests that, within economists, short-run exposure is not strongly associated with complete disengagement from the platform.

Second, we continue to find statistically significant effects on the intensive margin, but the magnitudes are modest relative to the DiD estimates. A one standard-deviation increase in

Mastodon exposure is associated with reductions of roughly 0.5 tweets, 0.2 retweets, 0.3 replies, and 0.8 quotes per week. These results indicate that short-run exposure is related to a small decline in activity intensity, even when controlling for economist fixed effects and common week-level shocks.

Overall, controlling for economist and week fixed effects, the immediate relationship between Mastodon exposure and tweeting behavior appears limited in magnitude. This pattern is consistent with substantial stickiness in usage and highlights the resilience of engagement within #EconTwitter during a period of platform upheaval.

Tables 6 and 7 report heterogeneity results from the fixed effects specification, splitting economists by pre-period activity and connectivity (relative to the median). The estimates suggest that the modest average effects mask meaningful heterogeneity, with the strongest responses concentrated among more active and well-connected users.

[Table 6 about here.]

In Table 6, the association between Mastodon exposure and the likelihood of posting on #EconTwitter is more pronounced among economists with more followers, those who follow more accounts, and those who tweet more frequently. This suggests that exposure effects are concentrated among economists who are more embedded in the network and more engaged on the platform.

[Table 7 about here.]

Similarly, Table 7 shows larger declines in tweeting volume for the most active users following increased exposure. Taken together, the heterogeneity results are consistent with a "leader-follower" dynamic in which behavioral changes are concentrated among highly active and well-connected economists, who may also be most exposed to and engaged with migration-related discussions.

3.3 Long Run Impacts of Mastodon Exposure

We next examine whether exposure to Mastodon-related discussions during 2022–2023 is related to longer-run platform usage as of May 2025 (as constructed in Section 2.4). Because these outcomes are measured using a post-2023 snapshot rather than a complete activity panel, the results in this subsection are interpreted as longer-run associations conditional on observed covariates.

We estimate the following cross-sectional regression:

$$Y_i^{LR} = \beta_0^{LR} + \beta_1^{LR} Retweet_i^{mastodon} + \beta_2^{LR} X_i + \varepsilon_i, \tag{3}$$

where Y_i^{LR} is a long-run outcome. We consider extensive-margin outcomes (an indicator for whether the economist is active on a given platform as of May 2025) and intensive-margin outcomes (the number of posts made on that platform between March 2023 and May 2025), estimated separately by platform. $Retweet_i^{mastodon}$ denotes cumulative retweet-based Mastodon exposure as of March 2023. The covariates X_i include a verified account indicator, follower and following counts, and the number of X posts in 2022.

Table 8 reports the results. Columns (1)–(3) present extensive-margin outcomes (activity on X, Bluesky, and Mastodon), while columns (4)–(6) present intensive-margin outcomes (posts on each platform from March 2023 to May 2025).

We find that Mastodon exposure is related to long-run platform presence. A one-standard-deviation increase in Mastodon exposure is associated with about a 3 percentage point lower probability of being active on X nearly two years later, and with higher probabilities of being active on Bluesky and Mastodon (by about 9 and 6 percentage points, respectively). These differences suggest that higher exposure is associated with diversification across platforms (multi-homing), rather than a complete departure from X.

On the intensive margin, the estimates point to some reallocation of posting activity. Greater Mastodon exposure is associated with roughly 300 fewer posts on X and about 64 more posts on Bluesky during the post-2023 period. The relationship with Mastodon posting volume is not statistically significant.

Finally, the long-run associations, while statistically significant, are modest in magnitude relative to the short-run changes. This pattern is consistent with a rebound in activity and the resilience of a large network like X: exposure to migration-related discussions is correlated with greater experimentation and multi-homing, but only limited long-run disengagement from X.

[Table 8 about here.]

4 Conclusion

In this paper, we analyze the attempted and ultimately failed exodus of economists from Twitter/X following Elon Musk's acquisition of the platform. Using user-level data on tweeting behavior—with a particular focus on the #EconTwitter community—we examine the role of Mastodon as a potential alternative platform and the importance of network effects in sustaining engagement on Twitter/X. Overall, our findings highlight the resilience of network effects even amid substantial platform changes and widespread user dissatisfaction.

First, we document that despite a significant decline in #EconTwitter tweet volumes following the mass layoffs in November 2022 and the rollout of Twitter Blue, activity rebounded within a few months. This pattern suggests that Twitter/X's entrenched position as a key communication platform for academics, particularly in economics, made it difficult for users to fully disengage.

Second, in our short-run analyses, we find that greater exposure to Mastodon-related discussions circulating through economists' networks is associated with a decrease in Twitter/X activity. This relationship is most evident in baseline difference-in-differences estimates, but it becomes much smaller when we control for economist fixed effects and common week shocks in a narrow event window. Taken together, these results suggest that while migration-related discussions coincided with a short-run pullback in engagement, economists' usage was highly sticky, consistent with strong network effects.

Finally, our long-run evidence points to diversification across platforms rather than a large-scale exit from Twitter/X. Using a May 2025 snapshot of social media presence constructed after the discontinuation of free Twitter/X API access, we find that economists with higher exposure to Mastodon-related content are more likely to multi-home (e.g., adopt Bluesky or Mastodon) but only marginally less likely to remain active on Twitter/X. These longer-run patterns are consistent with the broader conclusion of a failed exodus: dissatisfaction and experimentation may induce some reallocation of attention across platforms, but the incumbent platform remains dominant within a specialized professional network.

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Appendix: Robustness Check on Mastodon Exposure

In the main analysis, we define indirect Mastodon exposure as Mastodon-related content that reaches an economist through retweets by accounts the economist follows, where the original author of the retweeted post is not followed by the economist (see Section 2.2). While this retweet-based exposure measure captures indirect exposure through the network, it may be disproportionately driven by a small subset of highly active peer accounts and therefore may not fully reflect the breadth of exposure sources.

To address this concern, we construct an alternative exposure measure based on the number of unique original accounts (not followed by the economist) that generate Mastodon-related content that is retweeted by accounts the economist follows. This alternative measure places greater emphasis on the diversity of exposure sources rather than the volume of retweet activity.

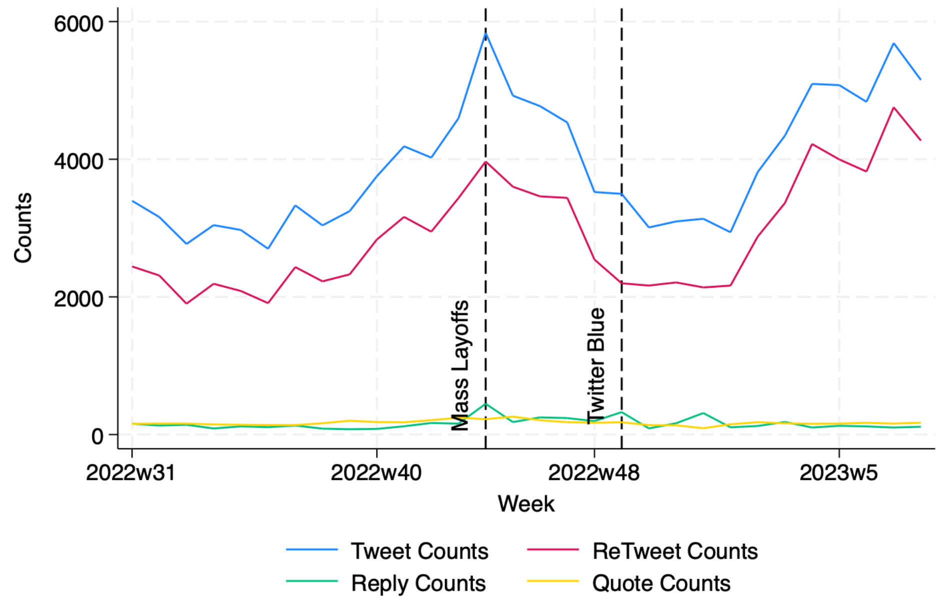
We replicate the main analyses using this alternative measure. The corresponding results are presented in Tables 9, 10, and 11, which mirror the specifications in Tables 4, 5, and 8, respectively. Across all specifications, the results remain qualitatively consistent with the main findings, reinforcing the robustness of our conclusions to alternative operationalizations of peer-based Mastodon exposure.

[Table 9 about here.]

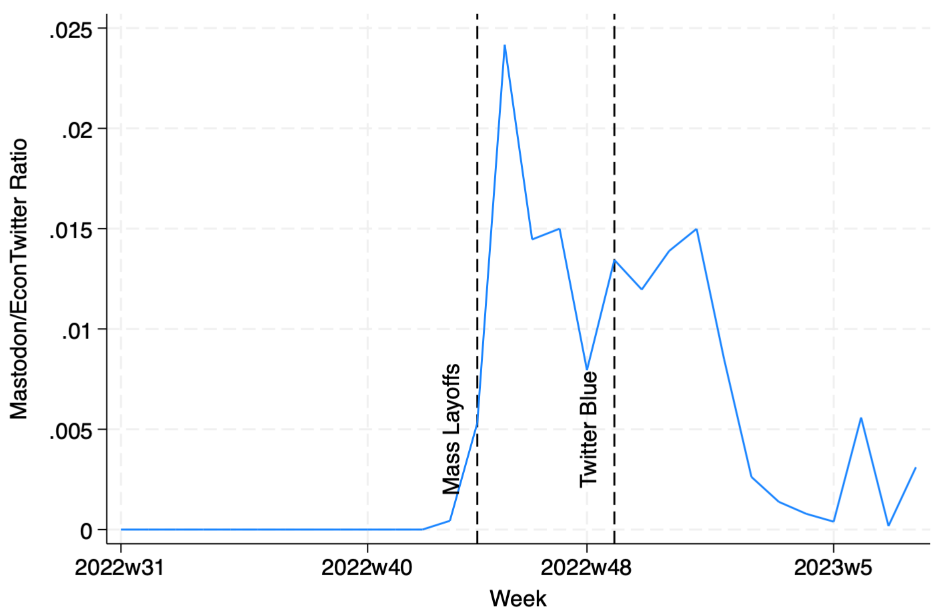
[Table 10 about here.]

[Table 11 about here.]

Figure 1: #EconTwitter Tweet Summary



(a) Overall Tweets



(b) Mastodon Ratio

Figure 2: Peers of Peers in Twitter/X Network

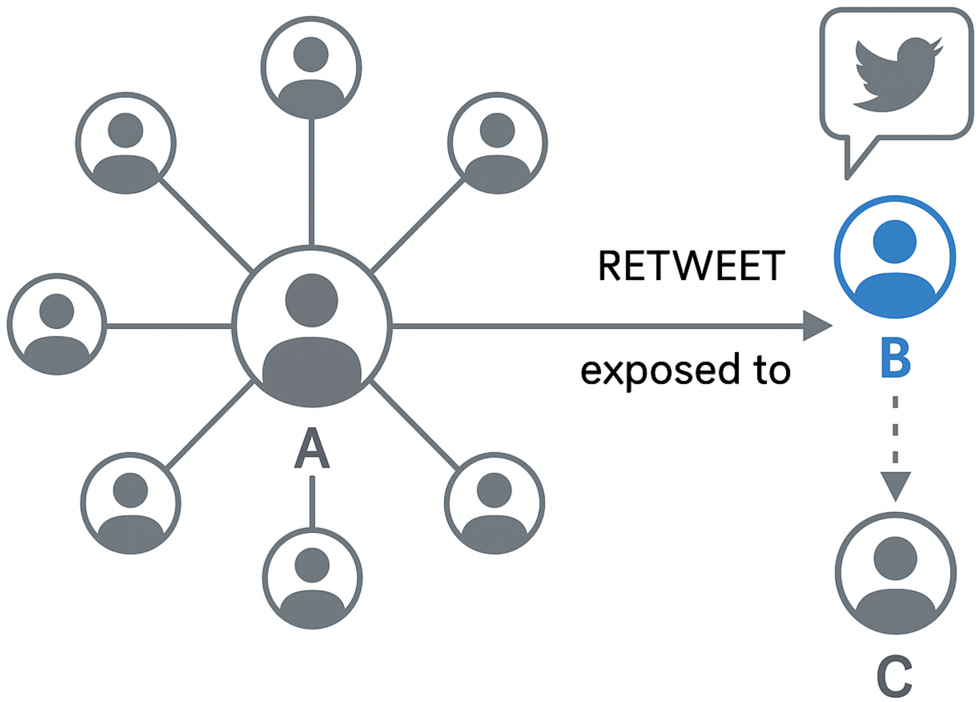


Table 1: RePEc User Summary by Mastodon Exposure

	High Exposure	Low Exposure	Total
# of Followers	7894.2	14634.8	11641.4
	(20533.7)	(137854.3)	(103743.7)
# of Following	1923.0	825.0	1312.6
	(3099.9)	(1886.6)	(2558.0)
User History (Yrs)	9.769	9.396	9.562
	(3.207)	(3.377)	(3.307)
Verified	0.0380	0.0468	0.0429
	(0.191)	(0.211)	(0.203)
Tweet Counts	15.17	9.863	12.22
	(33.23)	(26.50)	(29.79)
EconTwitter Exposure	137.8	34.89	80.62
(per week)	(115.4)	(40.02)	(97.06)

mean coefficients; sd in parentheses

Table 2: Changes in Tweeting Behavior Before and After Musk's Acquisition, by Mastodon Exposure

	High Exposure		Low Exposure		Total
	Before	After	Before	After	
Tweet Counts	13.84	16.15	8.605	10.51	12.10
	(27.95)	(36.57)	(20.79)	(30.38)	(29.87)
ReTweet Counts	4.801	5.765	3.126	3.671	4.278
	(11.54)	(16.69)	(9.650)	(14.97)	(13.81)
Reply Counts	5.828	6.724	3.017	3.740	4.707
	(15.89)	(19.96)	(10.10)	(14.79)	(15.64)
Quote Counts	1.349	1.529	0.859	1.021	1.171
	(3.550)	(4.298)	(2.858)	(3.841)	(3.713)
EconTwitter Counts	0.121	0.147	0.0275	0.0383	0.0784
	(0.574)	(0.644)	(0.229)	(0.356)	(0.471)

mean coefficients; sd in parentheses

Table 3: Long Run RePEc User Summary by Mastodon Exposure

	High Exposure	Low Exposure	Total
X (Dummy)	0.875	0.907	0.889
	(0.331)	(0.291)	(0.314)
X (Count)	766.4	916.6	835.4
	(6024.0)	(3331.0)	(4970.4)
Bluesky (Dummy)	0.663	0.460	0.572
	(0.473)	(0.499)	(0.495)
Bluesky (Count)	272.2	266.2	270.0
	(1049.2)	(1226.3)	(1116.2)
Mastodon (Dummy)	0.156	0.0605	0.113
	(0.363)	(0.238)	(0.317)
Mastodon (Count)	239.1	578.8	321.0
	(807.1)	(1433.2)	(1002.0)

mean coefficients; sd in parentheses

Table 4: Difference-in-Differences Results

	(1) Tweet (Y/N)	(2) EconTwitter (Y/N)	(3) Tweet (Count)	(4) Retweet (Count)	(5) Reply (Count)	(6) Quote (Count)
LayoffsXexposure	-0.0121***	-0.0109***	-0.539***	-0.150***	-0.313***	-0.0823***
	(0.00169)	(0.000765)	(0.0940)	(0.0403)	(0.0514)	(0.0122)
Observations	49258	49258	49258	49258	49258	49258
R^2	0.02	0.03	0.05	0.03	0.03	0.03

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 5: Economist Fixed Effects Results

	(1) Tweet (Dummy)	(2) EconTwitter (Dummy)	(3) Tweet (Count)	(4) Retweet (Count)	(5) Reply (Count)	(6) Quote (Count)
Mastodon Exposure	0.00186	-0.00803***	-0.372***	-0.106**	-0.177***	-0.0557***
	(0.00291)	(0.00187)	(0.111)	(0.0475)	(0.0670)	(0.0173)
Observations	20151	20151	20151	20151	20151	20151
R^2	0.02	0.01	0.04	0.04	0.03	0.03

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 6: Economist Fixed Effects Results (#EconTwitter Y/N) by Groups

	(1) Followers (Low)	(2) Followers (High)	(3) Following (Low)	(4) Following (High)	(5) Tweet (Low)	(6) Tweet (High)
Mastodon Exposure	-0.00211	-0.00974***	-0.00623	-0.00839***	-0.00468*	-0.00901***
	(0.00299)	(0.00262)	(0.00435)	(0.00261)	(0.00244)	(0.00281)
Observations	10080	10071	10071	10080	10080	10071
R^2	0.01	0.02	0.01	0.02	0.02	0.02

Standard errors in parentheses
* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 7: Economist Fixed Effects Results (Tweet Counts) by Groups

	(1) Followers (Low)	(2) Followers (High)	(3) Following (Low)	(4) Following (High)	(5) Tweet (Low)	(6) Tweet (High)
Mastodon Exposure	0.0747	-0.553***	0.183	-0.556***	0.0308	-0.571***
	(0.0849)	(0.181)	(0.208)	(0.166)	(0.0467)	(0.194)
Observations	10080	10071	10071	10080	10080	10071
R^2	0.05	0.04	0.03	0.05	0.02	0.05

Standard errors in parentheses
* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 8: Long Run Impacts of Mastodon Exposure

	Extensive Margin			Intensive Margin		
	X	Bluesky	Mastodon	X	Bluesky	Mastodon
Mastodon Exposure	-0.00360***	0.0107***	0.00695***	-37.13***	7.552**	-11.26
	(0.000833)	(0.00130)	(0.000827)	(14.01)	(3.129)	(7.902)
Verified	0.0501	0.130**	0.0892**	-401.3	-224.6*	657.8***
	(0.0353)	(0.0550)	(0.0351)	(549.9)	(126.0)	(249.8)
# of Followers	0.0000301	0.000124	0.000220***	0.342	4.511***	-0.224
	(0.0000663)	(0.000103)	(0.0000658)	(1.018)	(0.202)	(0.221)
# of Following	0.00342	-0.00198	-0.00335	16.55	-2.475	70.35
	(0.00283)	(0.00441)	(0.00281)	(43.78)	(9.828)	(46.67)
Tweet Counts ('000)	0.000867**	0.000198	0.000486	66.60***	7.347***	4.406
	(0.000362)	(0.000564)	(0.000359)	(5.667)	(1.577)	(3.535)
Constant	0.901***	0.490***	0.0580***	516.7***	90.84**	231.0**
	(0.00898)	(0.0140)	(0.00891)	(146.7)	(37.96)	(96.71)
Observations	2239	2239	2239	1991	1280	253
R^2	0.01	0.04	0.04	0.07	0.30	0.07

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 9: Difference-in-Differences Results (Unique-Origin Exposure)

	(1) Tweet (Y/N)	(2) EconTwitter (Y/N)	(3) Tweet (Count)	(4) Retweet (Count)	(5) Reply (Count)	(6) Quote (Count)
LayoffsXexposure	-0.0500***	-0.0364***	-3.454***	-0.834***	-2.158***	-0.395***
	(0.00443)	(0.00201)	(0.246)	(0.106)	(0.135)	(0.0321)
Observations	49258	49258	49258	49258	49258	49258
R^2	0.02	0.03	0.06	0.03	0.03	0.04

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 10: Economist Fixed Effects Results (Unique-Origin Exposure)

	(1) Tweet (Dummy)	(2) EconTwitter (Dummy)	(3) Tweet (Count)	(4) Retweet (Count)	(5) Reply (Count)	(6) Quote (Count)
Mastodon Exposure	0.000775	-0.00903***	-0.353***	-0.0923*	-0.177**	-0.0591***
	(0.00343)	(0.00221)	(0.131)	(0.0560)	(0.0790)	(0.0204)
Observations	20151	20151	20151	20151	20151	20151
R^2	0.02	0.01	0.04	0.04	0.03	0.03

Standard errors in parentheses
* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$

Table 11: Long Run Impacts of Mastodon Exposure (Unique-Origin Exposure)

	Extensive Margin			Intensive Margin		
	X	Bluesky	Mastodon	X	Bluesky	Mastodon
Mastodon Exposure	-0.00427***	0.0114***	0.00890***	-60.03***	11.07**	-21.72**
	(0.00118)	(0.00179)	(0.00121)	(20.92)	(4.308)	(10.29)
Verified	0.0612	0.103*	0.0855**	-704.2	-397.9***	247.7
	(0.0383)	(0.0581)	(0.0394)	(626.1)	(132.9)	(243.4)
# of Followers	0.0000307	0.0000847	0.000232***	0.282	4.674***	-0.0811
	(0.0000686)	(0.000104)	(0.0000705)	(1.109)	(0.204)	(0.208)
# of Following	0.00304	-0.00490	-0.00419	22.56	-9.616	133.1***
	(0.00294)	(0.00445)	(0.00302)	(47.82)	(9.919)	(46.01)
Tweet Counts ('000')	0.000985**	0.000539	0.000442	67.66***	8.296***	-1.621
	(0.000422)	(0.000640)	(0.000434)	(6.995)	(1.659)	(3.501)
Constant	0.893***	0.540***	0.0714***	568.5***	89.52**	246.4***
	(0.0103)	(0.0156)	(0.0106)	(178.4)	(40.91)	(94.18)
Observations	1847	1847	1847	1633	1127	236
R^2	0.01	0.03	0.04	0.06	0.34	0.05

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < .1$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$